EU wavers on 'associate membership' for Canada

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【メール原文】

Presented by TikTok By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with GERARDO FORTUNA and GREGORIO SORGI GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's go: In today's Playbook: — Playboo

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's go:

In today's Playbook:

— Playbook breaks down what's in the Commission's long-awaited reform plans.

— Exclusive: How the EU plans to raise money for its budget via a global minimum tax.

— Faces in the crowd: Ursula von der Leyen, Catherine Day, Cristiano Sebastiani, Emmanuel Macron, António Costa, Alberto Núñez Feijóo, Viktória Lőrincz, Piotr Serafin, Gadi Eisenkot, Viktor Orbán and more …

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick break down what a new and improved European Commission might look like.

A message from TikTok: Did you know TikTok advertising generated €31 billion in economic output across the EU in 2025? New research shows the platform helped businesses grow, supporting €13 billion in additional economic output for small and medium-sized businesses and helping millions of businesses reach customers across borders.

DRIVING THE DAY

NO "ASSOCIATE MEMBERSHIP" DEAL FOR CANADA: EU countries are split over whether to offer Canada "associate member" status in the bloc, days before leaders fly to Montréal for a summit to mark a new era in EU-Canada relations, four EU officials and diplomats told me, Zoya Sheftalovich and Sebastian Starcevic.

Brussels vs. capitals: The disagreement — which persisted after talks among EU ambassadors on Monday — highlights tension between Brussels and EU capitals, which were caught off guard when

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen first floated the idea during her State of the European Union speech in September.

Berlin opposed: While several countries showed “skepticism” yesterday about using the associate membership phrasing in the joint EU-Canada statement, Germany is still leading the push to have the term fully removed from the text, said two EU diplomats, granted anonymity to discuss the sensitive talks. A spokesperson for Berlin in Brussels didn’t immediately reply to a request for comment.

What to watch: The European Council, in charge of drafting the joint declaration, will circulate a new draft text today and invite countries to propose last-minute tweaks.

The key question: Will Germany dig in and veto the term? That might please Canada, which had proposed “alliance for the future” as a preferred way of describing its relationship with the EU.

But dropping it would amount to a backdown for von der Leyen. A compromise proposed by Italy would define the arrangement in the final text as an associate membership “as proposed by the European Commission,” or similar, allowing capitals to distance themselves from the term without nixing it. Two officials said they expected this longer formulation to be included in the draft text circulated today.

That’s not all: Countries are still ironing out joint language on financial support for Ukraine — a major priority for the EU, which is seeking additional contributions for Kyiv from Canada and the United Kingdom.

Fine print: Regardless of what ends up in the joint statement, the EU isn’t offering Canada a new partnership status right away. This week’s summit is about agreeing on areas, such as critical raw materials and Arctic security, where cooperation can be deepened. The next EU-Canada summit, which will take place in Europe in about a year, will determine what’s possible — and indeed how to describe the new relationship.

The bottom line: With U.S. midterm elections just over a week away, Brussels and Ottawa will be wary of triggering the ire of President Donald Trump while he’s at a campaign podium. Any hint of a formal EU-Canada partnership in the offing — including an EU proposal of associate membership for Canada — could prove just the trigger.

QUEBEC WANTS IN: Meanwhile, the new separatist-led government of Quebec is treating this week’s summit as the start of a wider diplomatic push to get the Canadian province in the room whenever Ottawa and Brussels strike deals that concern its powers.

The defense partnership: The military and industrial relationship between Ottawa and Europe is accelerating, although European officials, diplomats and analysts describe the link as a welcome with conditions , report Laura Kayali, Mike Blanchfield, Jacopo Barigazzi and Mason Boycott-Owen.

BIG AND BREAKING

FRONTEX TO GET A BIGGER BADGE: The Commission will propose giving the EU border agency new powers to return migrants outside the bloc as part of a sweeping overhaul of Frontex to be unveiled today, two officials told Gerardo Fortuna.

EUROPE’S RACE TO REPLACE STARLINK: The EU is fighting Elon Musk’s Starlink on at least five fronts , ranging from blocking access and boosting rivals, to drafting new rules aimed directly at undermining the tech mogul’s growing dominance over space-related initiatives, Mathieu Pollet reports.

MINISTERS OFFER KYIV COMMITMENT: Top European defense ministers and EU representatives said Ukraine faces challenging months ahead, insisting they must keep supporting Kyiv despite the U.S. bid for talks with Russia.

ISRAELIS VOTE: Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has confounded his critics and found himself in a tight race for reelection in today's vote, three years after the Oct. 7 Hamas-led attacks on Israel.

A NEW-LOOK COMMISSION?

THE GREAT COMMISSION SHAKE-UP (KIND OF): Long-awaited recommendations for reforming the Commission are now in, drawn up by a group led by former Commission Secretary-General Catherine Day. Playbook has read her 35-page document and spoken to several EU officials … and here are four takeaways.

1. DGs (but not agencies) can breathe easy: There will be no merging of Commission departments — at least, not yet. The report warns that reorganizing DGs would cause "a lot of upheaval, which is not necessary, we think," a senior official told Gerardo Fortuna. Cue a collective sigh of relief in the Berlaymont, where several DGs feared the chopping block . EU agencies aren't so lucky, with the group suggesting a moratorium on creating new ones and a review of existing bodies, with mergers and transfers of responsibilities a possibility.

2. All roads lead to the SecGen: The Commission's Secretariat-General would gain more power to coordinate departments and settle disputes. Given that it's an administrative hub under the authority of the Commission president, its beefed-up role would amount to quite a power shift. Cristiano Sebastiani, of staff union Renouveau & Démocratie, warned that such centralization would need safeguards against abuses of power.

3. No cuts, but keep your bags packed: No staff reductions or reopening of the EU Staff Regulations are in the recommendations. Instead, the advisers want to redeploy officials as needed and enforce five-year rotations for senior managers. But Sebastiani warned that compulsory moves without guaranteed new posts could leave managers vulnerable.

4. AI, meet omnibus: The advisers want artificial intelligence to be used to spot overlapping rules, compare national legislation and slash paperwork. They also propose reviewing the EU's entire rule book every five years — with a little help from AI to weed out obsolete legislation and unnecessary reporting requirements.

What now: These are proposals from an external advisory group, not binding decisions by von der Leyen or Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin. But they are seen by officials as being influential on the final report, due by the end of the year.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The U.S. has reportedly encouraged former Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán to become a candidate for the role of U.N. secretary-general. But who is likely to get the U.N. job? There are seven candidates (Orbán isn't one of them and neither is FIFA boss Gianni Infantino, another reported Donald

Trump pick) to replace António Guterres when his term ends on Dec. 31. The U.N. Security Council holds secret votes on the candidates and the last straw poll ended with Rebeca Grynspan, of Costa Rica, in the lead. Emirati diplomat Lana Nusseibeh has now entered the race.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked how you celebrate Halloween — and what you think of the EU recommendation to decorate pumpkins instead of carving them. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

ONE IN, ONE OUT

EXCLUSIVE — COMMISSION EYES TAX RESHUFFLE: The European Commission is exploring whether to use revenue from a global corporate tax arrangement targeting large multinationals to finance the EU's next seven-year budget, four EU diplomats with knowledge of the proceedings told Gregorio Sorgi. They were granted anonymity to discuss the confidential plans.

Own resources, à la carte: The idea, which was backed by French President Emmanuel Macron in a leaders' meeting in October, could facilitate an agreement on new EU-wide taxes, known as own resources. After more than a year of negotiations, EU governments are still arguing over five proposed new taxes that the Commission estimates would generate €65 billion per year.

European Council President António Costa's advisers and the Commission are discussing whether to drop or tweak some of the proposed levies to make them more palatable to EU governments. A corporate tax, known as CORE, has emerged as the most unpopular option and is particularly toxic in Germany.

CORE victim: One of the solutions under consideration involves replacing CORE with a contribution to the EU budget based on the OECD's global minimum tax deal.

The agreement, which was implemented across the EU, compels countries to charge a minimum corporate tax rate of 15 percent and to levy a "top up" tax on foreign companies that manage to sidestep the minimum rate. European capitals could funnel part of the revenue from the "top up" tax to the bloc's budget, the diplomats said.

Europe's future is being decided now, and you can help shape it. Next week, join the European Pulse Seminar , where top decisionmakers like Michel Barnier and Aura Salla will join the discussion on how the European Pulse Poll findings collide with the reality of policymaking in Brussels. Here's the twist: your input, shared online or on-site, will help shape the questions we ask Europeans in the 2027 Poll. Register now to join onsite or online and be part of the conversation.

DASHBOARD

Tobacco and nicotine lobbyists meet with right-leaning MEPs three times more often than they do with left-leaning lawmakers, according to POLITICO's analysis of data collected by anti-smoking NGOs. Lawmakers declared more than 400 meetings so far during this parliamentary term, compared with just over 100 in the entire previous term.

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

FRANCO-GERMAN DEAL WON'T FIX AUTO CRISIS: A deal between France and Germany on cars has helped break a stalemate in the European Parliament on two major industry measures, but won't address the acute problems facing automakers , Jordyn Dahl and Giorgio Leali report.

U.K. DEFENSE BOOST: Chancellor John Healey is set to deliver an unexpected increase in defense spending in his first budget on Wednesday, as Britain strains to meet its NATO spending commitment. POLITICO delves into seven key questions .

WASHINGTON LASHES EU AIRBUS LOAN: U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer has slammed the EU's $3.4 billion loan to Airbus, warning the payment to the aerospace company could harm the trade truce between Washington and Brussels, the FT reports .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Showers in the afternoon, top of 18C.

ZEN AND THE ART OF EU REGIONS: With DG REGIO removed from the chopping block (for now) and cohesion funding still facing an uncertain future, Europe's regions could use a little peace of mind. And where better to find it than at the European Committee of the Regions?

Holy symphony! The Committee is hosting the WuLe Symphony Orchestra, billed as the world's largest symphony orchestra made up entirely of monks, which is performing for free at 3 p.m. as part of a day of cultural events that kicks off at 10 a.m. Founded and conducted by Maestro Shi Wule, the orchestra blends Chinese musical traditions with Western classical music, spreading a message of peace and dialogue.

It's a real thing: Brussels is a stop on the orchestra's 2026 European tour, ahead of performances at the Berlin Philharmonie on Oct. 29 and Milan's Teatro degli Arcimboldi on Nov. 2. No ticket prices here, no budget negotiations either … just (inner) harmony. For once.

GREAT PUMPKIN POLICY: Halloween is coming and the Commission's DG SANTE has some advice for Brussels' pumpkin carvers : Don't waste your jack-o'-lantern. The health department suggests decorating pumpkins instead of carving them, so they stay fresh enough to cook. Turn the flesh into soup, risotto or cake, and roast the seeds for a snack. One warning: Make sure your pumpkin is still edible and hasn't spoiled.

CULTURE ON THE FRONTLINE: For a change of pace from the usual Ukraine policy debates, head to Beursschouwburg in the city center for "LANDING," a documentary about young people skating, making music and building community in Okhtyrka, in Ukraine's Sumy region, which is close to the active frontline. Event from 5:30 p.m. to 9:30 p.m., with the film starting at 6 p.m.

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TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The Merz government has been careful not to comment on Israel's election, yet it's no secret that Gadi Eisenkot is broadly seen as the preferred candidate .

Paris: Fresh polling offers France's centrist candidates a glimmer of hope , suggesting voters could turn to Macron's heirs to block the far right and far left.

Madrid: People's Party leader Alberto Núñez Feijóo is determined to compile a list of candidates that excludes people who lack local ties.

London: Chancellor John Healey is set for a jogging interview with the BBC , after the pre-budget announcement of five more "everyday fixes."

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AGENDA

— The College of European Commissioners meets in Brussels.

— Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen and Internal Affairs Commissioner Magnus Brunner present plans to strengthen Frontex. Watch here.

— The United Nations Biodiversity Conference (COP17) continues in Yerevan, Armenia, running through Friday. Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall attends and meets Armenian Prime Minister Nikol Pashinyan, U.N. Environment Programme Executive Director Inger Andersen, Canadian Environment Minister Julie Dabrusin and Convention on Biological Diversity Executive Secretary Astrid Schomaker.

— Executive Vice-President Roxana Mînzatu delivers the keynote address at the Equal Pay Day conference in Budapest and meets Hungarian social partners, parliamentary committees, Children and Education Minister Judit Lannert, Social and Family Affairs Minister Vilmos Kátai-Németh and Rural and Urban Development Minister Viktória Lőrincz.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič meets European Central Bank President Christine Lagarde in Frankfurt.

— Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica delivers a keynote speech at European Hydrogen Week in Brussels.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in the Eighth Annual Conference on Regulatory Scrutiny in Brussels.

— Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen has an online meeting with U.K. Energy Secretary Miatta Fahnbulleh.

— Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen attends a European Council of Young Farmers working group on generational renewal and receives representatives of Finnish, Estonian, Lithuanian and Latvian agricultural organizations.

— Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera meets Jens Eskelund, president of the European Union Chamber of Commerce in China, in Brussels.

— Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto meets representatives of the National Association of Italian Municipalities in Rome.

— Crisis Management Commissioner Hadja Lahbib visits De Havilland Canada in Calgary.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Tom Vandendriessche and Salvatore De Meo; former MEPs Theodoros Zagorakis and Janusz Korwin-Mikke; The Economist's Tom Nuttall; FleishmanHillard's Donald Ricketts; POLITICO's Mizy Clifton; and Johan Barros of Accountancy Europe.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Gregorio Sorgi and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

A message from TikTok: Did you know TikTok advertising generated €31 billion in economic output across the EU in 2025? New independent research shows the platform helped businesses grow, acting as a discovery engine for opportunity across the European economy. The impact goes well beyond the app. Advertising on TikTok helped generate €13 billion in additional economic output for small and medium-sized businesses, while more than 6.5 million EU businesses used TikTok to reach customers across borders. Discovery on TikTok helps small businesses connect with new customers, creators reach new audiences, and useful ideas and skills travel between countries. These connections can translate into real-world growth, from increased sales for local businesses to new opportunities for entrepreneurs and creators. Across the EU, TikTok is turning online discovery into economic activity, helping businesses grow and connecting people and products across borders.

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